

Tussock Sedge

Carex stricta

Upright Sedge



QUALITIES

A robust clumping sedge of fens, sedge meadows, and vegetated bioswales, forming distinct elevated "tussocks" 1 to 3 feet tall. Bright green narrow blades arch outward from a tightly clumped base; the tussock structure literally raises the plant slightly above the wet ground around it. Inconspicuous spring spikelets ripen to brown by midsummer. The fibrous root mat is the species' superpower — it armors flow paths in a way no other plant matches.

CARE

Plant from plug stock at 9 to 12 inches spacing in wet or moist soil — the closer spacing matters because the purpose is rapid canopy closure to outcompete weeds and armor against erosion. Tolerates seasonal flooding; tolerates partial drying once established. Full sun to part shade. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. No maintenance needed; can be selectively burned in a controlled spring burn.

HISTORY

Carex stricta was a dominant species of Minnesota's pre-settlement sedge meadows, which historically covered substantial acreage in poorly-drained lowlands across the state. Most sedge meadow has been tilled and converted to agriculture. The sedge meadow is one of the great "missing" Minnesota habitats — and tussock sedge is its keystone species. Each vegetated bioswale planted with **Carex stricta** is a small fragment of restored sedge meadow.

REASON TO BE

Tussock sedge is the structural species of a vegetated bioswale — the species that physically holds soil against stormwater flow with its dense fibrous root mat. Without sedge, a swale is just lawn or ditch; with sedge, it is a functioning piece of green stormwater infrastructure. The tussock form provides habitat for amphibians, ground-nesting birds, and specialist insects. As a substitute for a rock dry-creek it is an order of magnitude more ecologically valuable, and (after year 1) more visually beautiful.